Daniel holds off Seneca in rivalry win
By Caleb James
For The Journal

CENTRAL — In a rivalry game that stayed competitive late into the final quarter, The Daniel High School boys basketball team leaned on their consistent offense to beat Seneca 61-53 on Tuesday night.

The Lions and Bobcats traded blows early, with Daniel scraping ahead 5-4 following a free throw from Jackson Conley before Seneca's Andre Seay tied the game at 10-10 later in the opening period. Neither team managed to create much difference in the first half, and Daniel carried a slim 31-26 lead into the locker room at halftime.

Daniel began to create distance coming out of the break, as Emory McIntyre opened the third quarter with a 3-point shot before adding another basket moments later to push the Lions lead to 36-26. Conley later scored inside to extend the margin to 40-30, but Seneca responded by staying aggressive on offense.

Kingston Bibb ended the third quarter with an and-one, giving Daniel a 43-37 lead going into the final eight minutes.

Seneca battled late into the game, with Seay scoring a pair of baskets in the fourth quarter to cut the deficit to six. His final bucket with under a minute remaining cut Daniel's lead to 56-50 and gave the Bobcats one final push of momentum. Daniel eventually closed the door at the free-throw line, as James Epting made two late foul shots to seal the win.

"I thought we showed a lot of resilience," Daniel head coach Ben Touchberry said. "Our execution down the stretch was pretty good, and we made some really key free throws. That was the difference."

Touchberry said the focus moving forward is continuing to build momentum while sharpening execution.

"We're just trying to go 1-0 every time we step on the floor," he said. "We want to keep improving our chemistry and stay locked into the moment."

Conley added, "We need to keep doing what we're doing, until the next game, until we get to region and win the region."

Despite the loss, Seneca head coach Kevin Padgett was encouraged by his team's effort.
"I'm proud of our fight," Padgett said. "There were times where we could've folded, but we didn't. In an environment like this, that matters."

Padgett added that handling the pace and atmosphere of rivalry games will be a point of emphasis as the season goes on.

Daniel 66, Seneca 26
DHS 16 15 12 18 — 61
SHS 14 12 11 16 — 53

Daniel (61) — Conley 15, Epting 11, McIntyre 9, Swan 7, Bibb 7, Johnson 6, Bell 4, Freeman 2
Seneca (53) — Seay 16, Hunter 13, Russell 10, Moss 7, McGee 5, Cleveland 2